

DECEPTIVE CALM? A Dhangar herder with his flock of sheep in Pune district

INDIA PICTURE

this would make Marathas eligible for quota too. The demand is opposed by Kunbi and other OBC groups. Patil withdrew his agitation on September 14 after chief minister Eknath Shinde promised reservation for Marathas. The Supreme Court had in May 2021 struck down a law that granted exclusive reservation to Marathas.

Taking a leaf out of the Maratha protests, Dhangar activists launched a hunger strike at Choundi in Ahmednagar on September 6. The protest was called off on September 26 after the state government promised that the technical aspects for the inclusion of Dhangars in the ST category would be taken care of in 50 days. Girish Mahajan, senior BJP leader and minister for rural development, says the state government is "very positive" about the demand.

But a senior BJP leader admits the issue has them caught in a quandary. Before the 2014 Lok Sabha and state assembly polls, the BJP had reached out to Dhangar leaders like Mahadeo Jankar, who heads the Rashtriya Samaj Party (RSP), and rode on the community's support to come to power in the state. Jankar was later made a state minister. It also promoted Dhangar leaders like Ram Shinde and Gopichand Padalkar. However, the reclassification demand is being resisted by tribal leaders, including those from Vidarbha, a BJP stronghold. The saffron party holds three of the four Lok Sabha seats reserved for the STs—Nandurbar, Gadhchiroli, and Dindori. The fourth, Palghar, is represented by the Shinde faction of the Shiv Sena. Similarly, the BJP has an edge in the 25 ST seats in the assembly. Over the years, Sangh parivar fronts like the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram and the Vishwa Hindu Parishad have made inroads in tribal-dominated areas, which has translated into tangible political gains for the BJP.

There are stringent norms to identify a tribal group. After a study

WHO ARE THE DHANGARS?

The ST population in Maharashtra was estimated at around 9.35 per cent in the 2011 census, comprising 48 tribes like Bhils, Gonds, Mahadeo Kolis, Pawras, Thakars and Warlis. The Katkaris, Kolams and Madia Gonds are classified as 'primitive tribal groups'

- The Dhangars claim to be the descendants of the original pastoral inhabitants of Maharashtra
- According to British administrator R.E. Enthoven whose *The Tribes and Castes of Bombay* formed a part of the Ethnographic Survey of India, the Dhangars in the Deccan and Konkan lost their original tribal signification and came to denote a heterogeneous group of distinct races who were sheep-rearers
- King Chhatrapati Shahu of Kolhapur, a Maratha, married his cousin to Yashwantrao Holkar, the crown prince of Indore. The Holkars were Dhangars by caste
- Shahu's religious advisor Gundopant Pishwikar (Dharmadhikari), however, wrote to him that he had examined a genealogy of the Holkars, which claimed that they were Rathod Kshatriyas. The marriage took place in 1924
- The Maharashtra government in May approved a demand to rename Ahmednagar district as Ahilyanagar after warrior-queen Ahilyadevi Holkar of Indore